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2 Dean Trench Street · Westminster · London SW1P 3HE · United Kingdom · ej@res.org.uk

MS 20251566 "Educated to Be Mothers? School Reform and Demographic Backlash" by Gema Lax-Martinez, Marco Le Moglie and Matteo Sand

Dear all,

Thank you for submitting your paper to *The Economic Journal*.

I am writing to inform you that I have decided to desk-*reject* your submission to save you time. I enjoyed reading your paper and to learn about this setting and the Franco reforms. Yet, I was not convinced that the value-added of this paper is big enough for a top general interest journal like *The Economic Journal*. This is partly a function of the nature of the "experiment", which after all is a simple before/after treatment, where identification and detection of mechanisms is genuinely hard to achieve. It is an uphill battle to show that the lower fertility in the 1939-1950 cohort is not merely part of a secular decline in fertility. I don't think your "Analysis at the macro level" in Section 5.3 really addresses the issue either. Even if the nature of the drop in fertility was sharper and attributable to the reform beyond any doubt, the fact that you cannot say much about mechanisms limits the value-added for a top general-interest journal.

I feel that a field journal in labour economics would be a better fit for your paper, but you might want to address some of the points below.

Here are some additional notes I took along the way as I was reading your paper, in no particular order. I hope some are useful:

✓ Related work: "Pronatalist policies' backlash in authoritarian regimes" by Thomas Baudin and Robert Stelter is a paper about Nazi policies.

Sentences like "However, no studies to date have empirically examined whether an educational reform can work to stimulate fertility in future generations." are risky. It will send (some) referees on a hunt to find a counter-example.

	(1) Kids	(2) N. kids
1930/1938	-0.018	-0.629
	(0.020)	(0.399)
1939/1950	-0.061	-0.702
	(0.039)	(0.427)
Observations	751	751
R-squared	0.015	0.025
Year FE	YES	YES
Age class FE	YES	YES
Base value	.88	2.89

The results for Portugal are problematic for two reasons:
The point estimates are even larger than in Spain:

Table 1: The impact of Francoist primary school reform on fertility

	(1) Kids	(2) Kids	(3) Kids	(4) Kids	(5) N. kids	(6) N. kids	(7) N. kids	(8) N. kids
1930/1938	0.012	0.010	-0.014	-0.006	-0.079	-0.061	-0.056	-0.177
	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.069)	(0.067)	(0.106)	(0.131)
1939/1950	0.017	0.013	-0.004	0.002	-0.370***	-0.401***	-0.260**	-0.344**
	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.065)	(0.063)	(0.128)	(0.149)
Observations	4,157	4,157	4,157	3,944	4,153	4,153	4,153	3,940

The smaller sample size in Portugal alone might be the reason for the wider confidence intervals.
You might want to check Gelman and Stern's "The Difference Between "Significant" and "Not Significant" is not Itself Statistically Significant".
If you produce a chart of fertility trends across all European countries: Does Spain stand out?

Bibliography:
a. you need to spell out all author names and avoid "et al.". One example: "Adena, M. et al. (2015). "Radio and the rise of the Nazis in Prewar Germany". In: The Quarterly Journal of Economics, pp. 1885–1939."
b. Information like Suite 305 is irrelevant: Bertrand, M. (2020). "Gender in the twenty-first century". In: AEA Papers and proceedings. Vol. 110. American Economic Association 2014 Broadway, Suite 305, Nashville, TN

I understand that this news is disappointing. Please note, however, that we accept only around 5 percent of submitted manuscripts, which means that we have to reject many good papers. In order to speed up and improve the submission process for both authors and referees, we have increased the number of papers that we reject without seeking a full set of reports. This decision is often made on the editor's view -- with, or without, consultation with an Associate Editor or other expert referee --, as to whether a submission is suitable for a broad-ranging general-interest journal. Thus, many rejections are made in the belief that a more specialised outlet is suitable. Our main aim in making this decision is to save you wasting potentially several months by tying your paper up at a journal where, in the editor's view, the eventual probability of success is low.

I am sorry for delivering bad news and hope that, at the very least, you do appreciate the absence of a delay in reaching the decision.

I thank you for having had the opportunity to consider your work and hope that, despite this negative outcome, you will still consider *The Economic Journal* for future submissions.

Sincerely,

Sascha O. Becker (Editor)